

THE ROLE OF MOTIVATION IN PROMOTING PERSONAL AND SOCIAL RESPONSIBILITY THROUGH PHYSICAL EDUCATION AND SPORT

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Abstract

1. Young people are increasingly exposed to, or exhibit, socially harmful behaviour, and education has a responsibility to help them develop personal and social responsibility. University students on sport-related courses are the physical education (PE) teachers and sports leaders of the future, and, if sufficiently motivated, are well placed to shape the values of the next generation. This study had three aims: to identify these students' motivational profiles; to establish how motivation relates to resilience, emotional intelligence, responsibility, and intentions to remain physically active after graduation; and to compare patterns by country and sex.

2. The researchers conducted a cross-sectional, cross-cultural quantitative study of 368 university students, 163 from Spain and 205 from Hungary, using a demographic questionnaire and six validated psychological scales. Both autonomous and controlled motivation were high, though autonomous motivation was stronger and correlated more closely with resilience, emotional regulation, and both forms of responsibility. Motivation was also positively linked to intentions to remain active. The authors therefore recommend combining the Teaching Personal and Social Responsibility model with the Sport Education Model in teacher training.

Introduction

3. Rapid social change places new demands on education. Schools are expected to provide environments that are not merely safe but genuinely respectful, supporting students' cognitive, emotional, moral, and social development and protecting them from what has been termed a "socially toxic" environment. PE can contribute to this broader aim rather than being confined to physical skill alone: positive emotional experience in PE appears to strengthen intrinsic motivation and, in turn, long-term commitment to health-related physical activity.

4. PE can also cultivate cooperation, self-discipline, and responsibility — but only if those who teach it understand how motivation works. Self-Determination Theory (SDT) distinguishes autonomous motivation, in which students act out of genuine interest or personal value, from controlled motivation, driven mainly by external pressure, rules, or rewards. SDT further proposes that autonomy, competence, and relatedness (a sense of connection to others) are basic psychological needs; where teaching supports them, students participate more willingly.

5. The Teaching Personal and Social Responsibility model (TPSR) frames responsibility as a five-level progression, from Irresponsibility, through Self-control and Involvement, to Self-responsibility and finally Caring. At the lower levels, learners may do little more than avoid disrupting others; at the higher levels, they work independently, take ownership of their actions, and support their peers. Sport offers a practical arena in which this progression can be observed and developed.

6. Young people must also learn to manage stress, which requires resilience — the capacity to recover and adapt positively after setbacks. Resilience has been linked both to autonomous motivation and to the effective regulation of emotion. Emotional intelligence (EI) — commonly divided into noticing one's emotions (attention), understanding them clearly (clarity), and repairing a negative mood (repair) — is similarly associated with well-being and with academic and social success.

7. PE therefore offers fertile ground in which emotional development, motivation, and responsibility can be cultivated together. It also matters that the future teachers delivering this content lead active lives themselves: their own experience is likely to make these principles more authentic and easier to transmit.

8. A cross-cultural comparison can further illuminate how educational tradition interacts with motivation. Hungary has historically maintained a more centralised, standardised system, a legacy of its pre-1989 political history; Spain moved towards greater decentralisation and regional autonomy after its transition to democracy in the 1970s. Comparing the two makes it possible to ask whether such divergence still shapes students today, or whether the patterns have converged.

9. The researchers tested five hypotheses, predicting: a difference between autonomous and controlled motivation; positive relationships between motivation and factors such as resilience and responsibility; a link between motivation and intentions to remain active; differences between Hungarian and Spanish students; and differences between male and female students.

Method

10. The study used a cross-sectional, cross-cultural comparative quantitative design. “Cross-sectional” means all data were collected at a single point in time, rather than following the same students over months or years — a decision with clear consequences for what the findings can show. The research was approved by the University of Murcia Research Ethics Committee, and all participants gave written informed consent, with anonymity guaranteed.

11. Participants were students on sport-related courses at the Hungarian University of Sport Sciences, Budapest, and the University of Murcia, Spain, selected at random from volunteers. Of the 368 students, 205 were Hungarian (53% male) and 163 Spanish (67% male). Their mean age was 22.7 years, ranging from 19 to 48, with some fourteen years of sporting participation on average. Notably, the sex balance differed between the two national samples, which complicates any straightforward comparison by sex.

12. Seven questionnaires were administered: one demographic, and six previously validated scales measuring academic motivation (distinguishing autonomous from controlled motivation and both from amotivation); satisfaction of the needs for autonomy, competence, and relatedness; emotional intelligence, subdivided into attention, clarity, and repair; resilience; personal and social responsibility; and intention to remain physically active. As the original instruments were in English, each was translated into Spanish and Hungarian by a bilingual speaker, then independently checked by a second, with disagreements resolved by discussion — a procedure intended to preserve equivalent meaning across languages. All scales showed acceptable internal consistency.

13. The data were analysed using multivariate analysis of covariance (MANCOVA), a technique suited to studies with several interrelated outcome measures. Thirteen variables were examined simultaneously, with country and sex as grouping factors and age as a control variable, since age appeared to affect several measures. The researchers reported not only statistical significance but also effect sizes, which indicate how substantial a difference is rather than merely whether it is unlikely to be due to chance. Because some variables breached MANCOVA's assumptions, the analysis was repeated using less demanding tests, with closely similar results.

Results and Discussion

14. Both forms of motivation were reported at high levels, with autonomous motivation stronger overall. The two were also strongly correlated, suggesting most students are driven by a mixture of personal interest and external reasons rather than one alone. Autonomous motivation showed medium-strength relationships with personal responsibility, social responsibility, emotional repair, and resilience, but only weak relationships with emotional attention, clarity, and intention to remain active. Controlled motivation correlated weakly with almost everything else.

15. Clear differences emerged between the national groups. Hungarian students reported a stronger sense of relatedness and, to a lesser extent, higher controlled motivation. Spanish students scored higher on autonomous motivation, emotional attention and repair, resilience, both forms of responsibility, and intention to remain active. The authors suggest these patterns may be connected to the countries' contrasting educational histories, while noting that the data cannot establish that national culture caused them.

16. At the broadest statistical level, no overall difference emerged between male and female students. Narrower analyses, however, revealed more specific patterns: Spanish males reported higher controlled motivation than Spanish females, while Hungarian females scored higher than Hungarian males on emotional attention and both forms of responsibility. Sex differences here were thus context-specific rather than uniform. The authors offer no firm explanation for the Hungarian pattern, suggesting tentatively that females may generally report higher emotional intelligence than males of similar age.

17. Autonomous motivation correlated positively with both forms of responsibility and with the desire to remain physically active — encouraging for anyone hoping to use sport to develop responsibility. Controlled motivation, by contrast, correlated negatively with resilience. The authors read this as possible evidence that students accustomed to external direction struggle more to make independent decisions under pressure, though correlation alone cannot confirm that one factor causes the other.

18. The authors therefore recommend combining TPSR with the Sport Education Model (SEM). Where TPSR foregrounds responsibility, self-direction, and care for others, SEM contributes cooperative learning structures and meaningful roles within a team. Earlier research on a similar hybrid reported reductions in bullying and violence alongside gains in perceived competence and social relationships — lending some support to the authors' expectation that strengthening autonomous motivation and responsibility should coincide with less bullying and disruptive behaviour.

Limitations and Future Research

19. These findings should be read cautiously. The study captured a single point in time, relied entirely on self-report, and drew on only two countries, all of which limit generalisability. Correlational data can reveal relationships and group differences, but cannot show that a particular type of motivation causes responsibility, resilience, or future activity. The authors call for larger, more internationally diverse studies and, crucially, for longitudinal intervention research comparing TPSR, SEM, the hybrid model, and a control group over time.

Conclusions

20. The findings support greater emphasis on cultivating autonomous motivation in the training of future PE teachers and sports leaders. The proposed TPSR–SEM hybrid may help build cooperation and responsibility while encouraging lifelong physical activity. The authors argue that this effort should pay particular attention to young male students, among whom preventing bullying remains a pressing educational priority.

21. More broadly, PE offers a setting in which reflection, autonomy, responsibility, and care for others can be practised and reinforced. If modelled consistently in sport and supported elsewhere, these behaviours may extend beyond the PE classroom into schools and society more widely. Whether the model delivers on this promise in practice remains a question for future evaluation.